

GOTOIT

The Six Steps of the Functional Medicine Clinical Method



KELECHI A. UDUHIRI, MD

APPLYING FUNCTIONAL MEDICINE IN CLINICAL PRACTICE

Disclosures

Kelechi A. Uduhiri, MD disclosed no relevant financial relationships with any ineligible companies.

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Functional Medicine Certification Competencies

I. PATIENT COMMUNICATION

- a) Identify what gives each patient meaning and purpose and use this information to inform clinical decisions within their personal and sociocultural context.
- b) Collaborate with the patient to understand their values, goals, preferences, and circumstances for the purpose of prioritization, selection, and initiation of the most feasible and effective interventions.
- c) Explain to the patient how their past and current life events, exposures, circumstances, and other factors (e.g., genetics, diet, lifestyle, mental/emotional/spiritual health, social determinants of health [SDOH], etc.) have contributed to current, or may contribute to future, clinical imbalances, health status, and/or physiological dysfunction.
- d) Educate and support the patient to initiate, sustain, and adjust personalized interventions to cultivate self-management and accountability.

Functional Medicine Certification Competencies

II. PATIENT EVALUATION

a) EVALUATION AND SYNTHESIS OF ROOT CAUSES

Elicit and understand personalized factors that enable the diagnosis of upstream disturbances in function and disease and understand when to refer for further evaluation to:

- i. Identify the latent root causes of current disturbances in function, inherited or acquired, that were predispositions (antecedents) to the patient's current health conditions. These latent root causes include genetics, exposures, significant past health events, behaviors/habits, circumstances, and other factors (e.g., diet, lifestyle, mental/emotional/spiritual health, social determinants of health [SDOH], occupational hazards, etc.).
- ii. Identify the rapidly acting root causes of disturbances in function throughout the course of the patient's life that were, or are, immediate activators/promoters (triggers) of their health conditions. These activating root causes include exposures, significant past and current life events, behaviors/habits, circumstances, and other factors (e.g., diet, lifestyle, mental/emotional/spiritual health, social determinants of health [SDOH], occupational hazards, etc.).
- iii. Identify the current, ongoing, or frequently occurring factors that serve as perpetuating root causes (mediators) of disturbances in function and whose presence prevents improvement of function. These perpetuating root causes include exposures, significant life events, behaviors/habits, circumstances, and other factors (e.g., diet, lifestyle, mental/emotional/spiritual health, social determinants of health [SDOH], occupational hazards, etc.).
- iv. Organize and synthesize information from the patient evaluation to construct a timeline of life events and factors that serve(d) as personalized root causes of disturbances in function.

Functional Medicine Certification Competencies

- v. Synthesize, integrate, and correlate the mechanisms of action of the clinical indicators and personalized root causes identified in the patient evaluation to identify, organize, and prioritize patterns of disturbance in function and clinical imbalances in the following domains:

- Production of energy and mitigation or modulation of the impact of oxidative stress & inflammation.
- Assimilation of nutrients, other substances (e.g., medications, hormones, toxicants), environmental factors, experiences, information (e.g., mental, emotional, spiritual health) into the body and mind.
- Transport of compounds, substances, and energy among cells, tissues, organs, and body systems.
- Production & balance of compounds (e.g., hormones, neurotransmitters) that mediate biochemical signals and information.
- Maintenance and optimization of structural integrity of the body from microscopic to macroscopic (e.g., cellular membrane to musculoskeletal system).
- Immune regulation, microbiome balance, and repair of inflamed or damaged tissues.
- Biotransformation and elimination of toxins, toxicants, and waste products.

b) GENERATION OF AN EXPLANATION OF THE PATIENT'S STATE OF FUNCTION

- Based on gathered data, generate an explanation of the most important root causes that contribute to the patient's current medical conditions and state of health, as well as those that are most likely to impact their prognosis and future health trajectory.

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III. THERAPEUTIC INTERVENTION

- a) Evaluate patient readiness to engage in dietary, lifestyle, and behavioral changes prior to initiating therapeutic interventions; prioritize these as initial interventional modalities.
- b) According to their ability to favorably modulate function, correct clinical imbalances, and/or address each patient's personalized root causes in alignment with the patient's goals, values, preferences, sociocultural context, and what gives them meaning and purpose:
 - i. Identify, prioritize, select, and initiate the following therapeutic interventions when clinically indicated:
 - Dietary and other lifestyle strategies.
 - Behavioral change strategies.
 - Pharmaceuticals, nutraceuticals, botanicals, and other supplements.
 - Mind-body and other modalities.
 - ii. Monitor changes in function in response to therapeutic interventions and adjust regimen accordingly.
 - iii. Refer and/or collaborate with additional healthcare practitioners, as needed or required, to align with the patient's goals and desired outcomes.

Learning Objectives

At the conclusion of this segment, successful participants will be able to:

1. List and describe the steps of the GOTOIT clinical method.
2. Explain how the GOTOIT clinical method is synergistic with the standard process of evaluating and treating patients.
3. Explain how the GOTOIT clinical method facilitates the identification of personalized root causes of physiological dysfunction and the initiation of personalized root cause treatment regimens regardless of the disease or diagnosis.

Clinical Focus

- The six steps of the functional medicine clinical method.



The Functional Medicine Clinical Method

GOTOIT: The six steps of the functional medicine clinical method



GOTOIT

The sequence of steps used in the practice of functional medicine:

GOTOIT Step and Definition	IFM Tools (examples)	Clinical Actions
G – GATHER oneself with a brief personal practice prior to prepare for each patient encounter. Take a detailed functional medicine history that includes the essential health events and features of a patient's life documented on the IFM Timeline in the process of organizing the patient's data.	- Cultivating Self Awareness and Mindfulness - Adult Intake Form - Medical Symptom Questionnaire (MSQ) - PROMIS Questionnaires - Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal - Functional Medicine Tree - Functional Medicine Timeline	- Use the Cultivating Self-Awareness and Mindfulness document to help gather yourself before every patient encounter. - The Adult Intake Form is used to gather initial intake information. Whereas, the MSQ, PROMIS Questionnaires, and Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal help gather initial symptom, function, and dietary information. - Map root causes (antecedents, triggers, mediators (ATMs)) and effects (clinical findings, current concerns) of physiological dysfunction on the Functional Medicine Timeline.
O – ORGANIZE the data gathered in the previous step and document them on the IFM Timeline and Matrix to identify the personalized root causes of current concerns, dysfunctions, and conditions, and to begin to prioritize the order (sequence) of interventions.	- Functional Medicine Tree - Functional Medicine Timeline - Functional Medicine Matrix - Adult Intake Form - Medical Symptom Questionnaire (MSQ) - PROMIS Questionnaires - Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal	Using the Functional Medicine Matrix, populate ATMs, clinical findings, and current concerns from the Timeline. Add modifiable lifestyle factors (MLFs) and mental, emotional, spiritual factors (MES) to support the identification of the most important areas of physiological dysfunction.
T – TELL the life story back to the patient to ensure accuracy and a shared understanding. This dialogue, focused on the Timeline, highlights how factors elicited in the Gather step may have contributed to current or future clinical findings, concerns, health status and trajectory. The patient is asked to join in correcting the story, engendering a context of true partnership.	- Functional Medicine Matrix - Functional Medicine Timeline - Functional Medicine Tree	- The Functional Medicine Timeline is used to re-tell the patient's story while correlating prior events and root causes with current concerns or conditions. Ask the patient to join in for corrections or additional context. - Use the Functional Medicine Tree to explain how the root causes have contributed to the patient's condition.

GOTOIT Step and Definition	IFM Tools (examples)	Clinical Actions
O – ORDER and collaboratively prioritize the most feasible and effective interventions by taking antecedents, triggers, mediators, and patient contextual factors into account.	- Functional Medicine Matrix - Readiness for Change - Goal Setting for Behavior Change - Integrating Guided Imagery and Visualization to Achieve Personal Health Goals	- Using the Functional Medicine Matrix, co-prioritize the areas of physiological dysfunction. - Assess if the patient is ready and committed to making changes with the Readiness for Change document. Use the Goal Setting for Behavior Change document to determine the patient's goals, values, preferences, and priorities. Then set SMART goals for interventions.
I – INITIATE Initiate interventions based on collaborative prioritization: 1) Evaluative, diagnostic, and prognostic testing. 2) Referral to another member of the collaborative care team for further assessment, intervention, or support. 3) Therapeutic interventions.	- Functional Medicine Tree - Functional Medicine Matrix - Functional Medicine Timeline - Goal Setting for Behavior Change - Functional Medicine Prescription and Lifestyle Plan	The Functional Medicine Prescription and Lifestyle Plan helps layout the therapeutic plan. This may include removing or reducing triggers, modifying lifestyle and dietary mediators, addressing gut health and function, implementing other therapeutic interventions, ordering appropriate laboratory tests, or referring as needed.
T – TRACK and monitor the effectiveness of, and adherence to, the initiated interventions as well as interval life events and changes in the patient's circumstances.	- Medical Symptoms Questionnaire (MSQ) - PROMIS Questionnaires - Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal	- Use tools to track progress by comparing scores at subsequent visits. The MSQ helps track symptom trajectory, the PROMIS Questionnaires help track overall well-being and quality of life, and the Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal helps track adherence to regimen. - There are many other tools and questionnaires that can be helpful for tracking progress.

Long Description: The Functional Medicine Clinical Method

- Toolkit item: The G O T O I T: The sequence of steps used in the practice of functional medicine; the six steps of the functional medicine clinical method

Gather

Gather oneself with a brief personal practice to prepare for each patient encounter.

Take a detailed functional medicine history that includes the essential health events and features of a patient's life documented on the IFM Functional Medicine Timeline in the process of organizing the patient's data.

Antecedents

Triggers

Mediators

Organize

the patient's data gathered in the previous step and document them on the IFM Timeline and Matrix to identify the personalized root causes of current concerns, dysfunctions, and conditions, and to begin to prioritize the order (sequence) of interventions.

Modifiable Lifestyle
Factors

Mental, Emotional,
Spiritual Factors

Domains/Nodes of
Dysfunction

Tell the life story back to the patient to ensure accuracy and a shared understanding.

This dialogue, focused on the timeline, highlights how the factors elicited in the Gather step may have contributed to current or future clinical findings, concerns, health status, and trajectory.

Therapeutic
Partnership

The patient is asked to join in correcting and amplifying the story, engendering a context of true partnership.

Order

and collaboratively prioritize the most feasible and effective interventions by taking antecedents, triggers, mediators, and patient contextual factors into account.

What Matters to the Patient?

Goals, Values, Preferences, Priorities

Context and Circumstances

Initiate

interventions based upon collaborative prioritization.

1. Evaluative, diagnostic, and prognostic testing.
2. Referral to another member of the collaborative care team for further assessment, intervention, or support.
3. Therapeutic interventions.

Primacy of Diet,
Lifestyle, and Gut

Judicious Use of
Labs & Supplements

Expansive Use of
Collaborative Care
Team

Track

and monitor the effectiveness of, and adherence to, the initiated interventions as well as interval life events and changes in the patient's circumstances.

Adjust and refine previous interventions and/or initiate new interventions as clinically indicated.

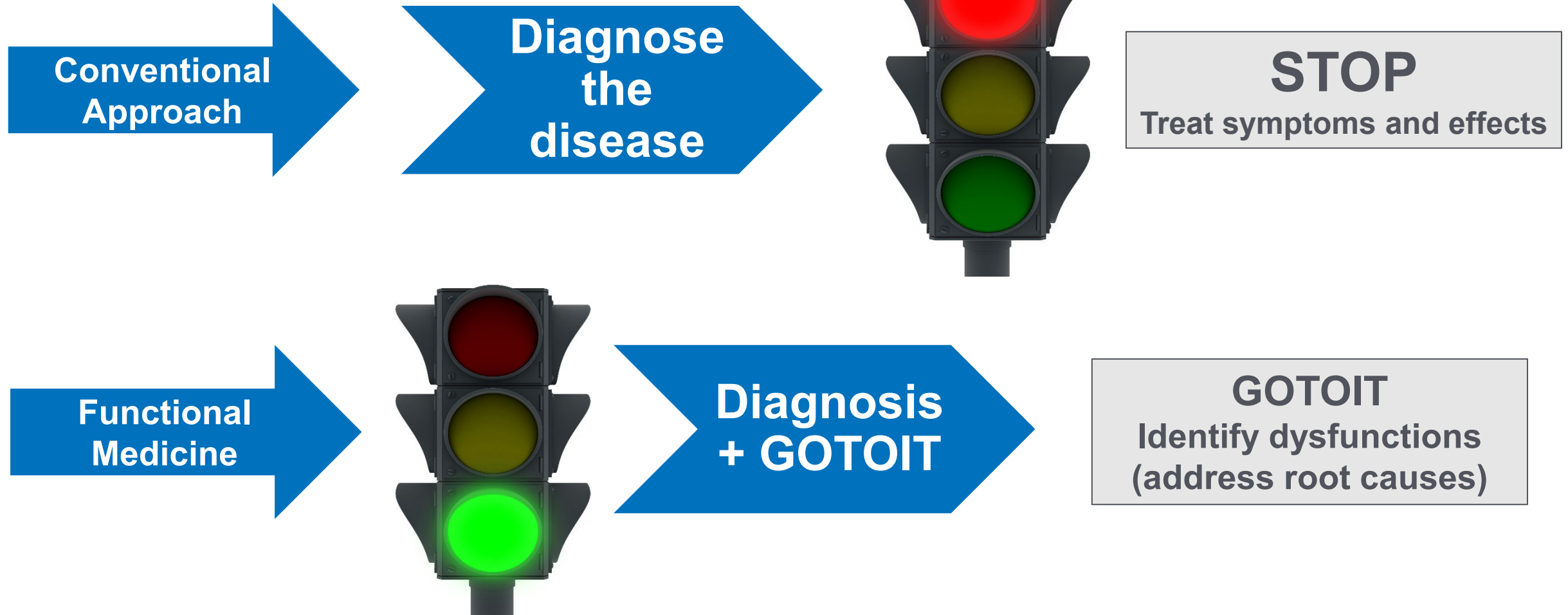
Results of
Testing

Response to
Treatments

Changes in Goals
and Circumstances

Patient Evaluation and Treatment

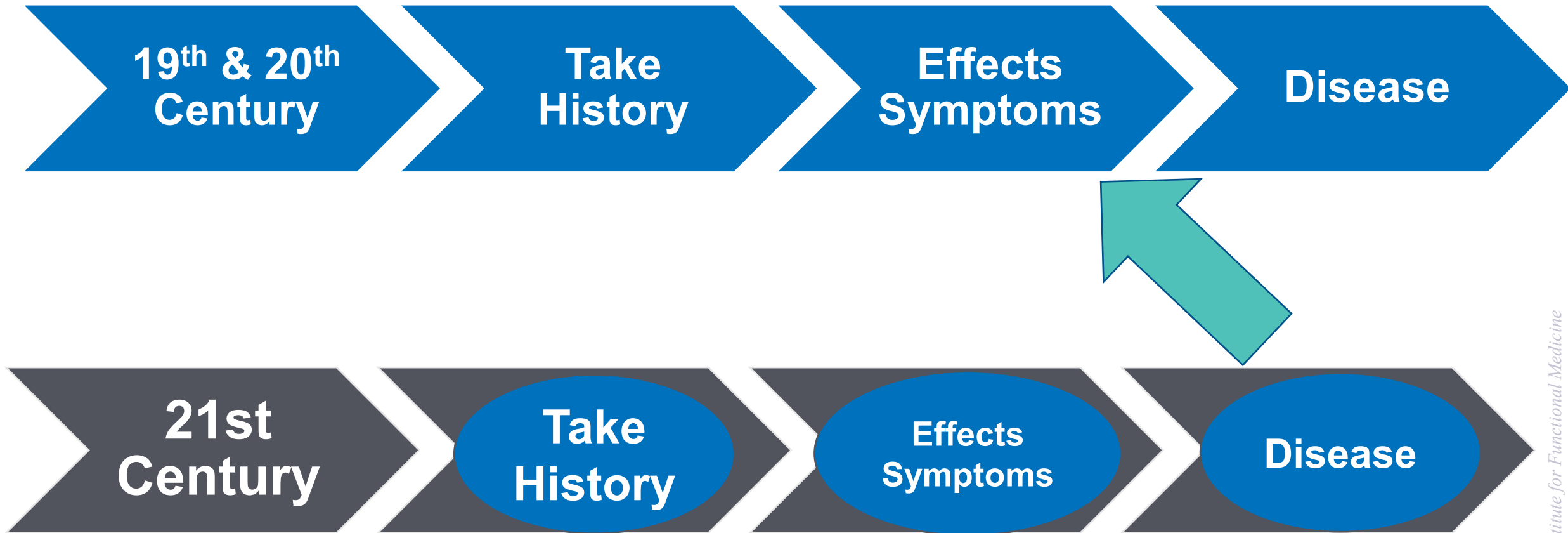
Where does it stop and start?



Long Description: Patient Evaluation and Treatment

- The current conventional medical approach diagnoses the disease but stops at treating the symptoms and effects. The functional medicine approach diagnoses the disease but then applies the G O T O I T model to identify dysfunctions and address the root causes of the disease.

Functional Medicine Approach to Chronic Disease:



Long Description: Functional Medicine Approach to Chronic Disease

21st century functional medicine does not just take the patient's history. Rather, it emphasizes identifying the patient's health events and tracking them on the functional medicine timeline. Instead of just identifying the patient's effects and symptoms, functional medicine identifies the root causes of disease. Rather than developing a differential diagnosis of diseases, functional medicine identifies a differential diagnosis of dysfunctions to explain the patient's effects and symptoms to treat and potentially reverse the disease.

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